What to Notice on an Ordinary Visit With Dad

Twelve everyday things worth a dated note, grouped by part of the day, with no diagnosing.

You see Dad every couple of weeks. You notice small things, and by the next visit they've blurred. This guide names twelve ordinary things worth noticing on an ordinary visit and, for each, what to jot down with the date.

Notice, and jot it down. Leave the interpreting out. Most of what you write will be unremarkable, and that's what makes it useful: it's the page later visits get compared with. What a change means is a question for his doctor. The areas below follow the everyday activities listed by the federal Administration for Community Living, with a few from AARP's and the Family Caregiver Alliance's guides for families; what to write down is our own wording.

Notice the way a guest would, not an inspector. Some things you won't see on a visit and shouldn't go looking for, such as how he manages in the bathroom. If Dad brings one up, note that he did and add it to the questions for his doctor.

The morning

1 Getting up and about [1]

NOTICE How he gets out of bed and up from his chair, what he puts a hand on, and how he moves from room to room.

WRITE DOWN What he does on his own and anything he uses: the chair arm, a rail, a cane.

2 Washing and dressing [1]

NOTICE What he mentions, or you happen to see, of his ordinary routine: shower or bath, shaving, buttons, shoes, and roughly how long the morning takes him.

WRITE DOWN What he does himself, and anything he does differently from the last time you noted it.

3 The morning pills [1] [3]

NOTICE How he keeps track: a pill box, the bottles on the counter, a written list, and who refills them. Ask him to show you his system. Don't count behind him.

WRITE DOWN His system as he describes it, and where the current list is kept. Questions go to his pharmacist or the prescriber. Change nothing.

Midday: the kitchen and the table

4 Making a meal [1]

NOTICE What he cooks for himself on an ordinary day, what comes ready-made or from someone else, and who does the washing up.

WRITE DOWN A typical day's meals and who made each one.

5 **At the table** [1]

NOTICE What an ordinary lunch looks like: what he chooses, how much of it he eats, how long the meal takes.

WRITE DOWN What you saw, with the date. Anything he mentions about appetite, chewing or swallowing goes on the question list for his doctor.

6 **The groceries** [1] [2]

NOTICE Who shops, how often, and how the bags get from the car to the kitchen.

WRITE DOWN Who does which part now, and roughly when that arrangement began.

The afternoon: the house and the errands

7 **The housework** [1]

NOTICE Which jobs he does himself and which someone else has picked up: the laundry, the lawn, the dog's walk.

WRITE DOWN Each job and who does it. “Dad does it” is worth writing down too.

8 **The mail and the bills** [1] [2]

NOTICE Who opens the mail, who pays the bills, who keeps the calendar.

WRITE DOWN Who handles what, and since when. Not the amounts; those are his business.

9 **Getting out** [2] [4]

NOTICE Where he goes on his own, when someone else drives, and how he gets to his appointments.

WRITE DOWN The trips in an ordinary week, and who was at the wheel for each.

10 **The phone** [1]

NOTICE How he answers, returns calls and follows a conversation on the line, and whether he uses a cell phone, the landline or both.

WRITE DOWN How you usually reach him, and what works best.

The evening: memory, mood and company

11 **Memory and mood**

NOTICE One specific thing, if there was one: an appointment that slipped, a story told twice, a quieter day than usual. And the ordinary too: the crossword finished, the joke that landed.

WRITE DOWN What happened, and the date. Leave out what you think it means.

12 **Who came by, and who helps** [2] [4]

NOTICE Who called or dropped in this week, and the small things each one does for him: a lift, a casserole, the bins brought in.

WRITE DOWN Each person, what they do, and roughly when it started.

When it's more than a note

A note is for ordinary things on ordinary days. If Dad tells you about a fall, a mix-up with his medicines or something that has become hard to do, or you see a change that concerns you, tell his doctor. You don't need to work out first whether it matters. At his next ordinary appointment you can also ask what the doctor would like to hear about between visits. An emergency is a call to emergency services.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't say what any of these mean, whether anything has changed, or whether Dad needs any help. That belongs to his doctor and the other professionals who know him, and dated notes give them something solid to work from.

Ready for the next step?

You've noticed an ordinary visit and put a date on it. The care interview covers the same ground in order, area by area, including the parts a visit doesn't show, and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

1. Administration for Community Living, What is Long-Term Care?
2. AARP, Prepare to Care: A Planning Guide for Families
3. Family Caregiver Alliance, Caregiver's Guide to Medications and Aging
4. Family Caregiver Alliance, Caregiving at Home: A Guide to Community Resources

From the Family Care Roadmap · Richard Ladson, Certified Medicaid Planner. Draft for review, generated 2026-10-04.